

UNIT IV - COMMUNICATIVE LANGUAGE

Communication Skills (English) — Course Code 311303

Overview

This unit develops **applied writing skills** used to describe, record, and translate real-world content — a key requirement in engineering and technical workplaces. It aligns with **CO4: “Use contextual words in English appropriately”** and covers four areas: Technical Object Description, Picture Description, Diary Entry, and Translation.

4.1 TECHNICAL OBJECTS (Description)

Describing a technical object means explaining what it is, what it looks like, and how it functions — in clear, structured, objective language. This is a core skill for engineers who must document equipment, tools, and components.

i. Heading

The heading names the object being described. It should be: - Short, precise, and centered/underlined at the top - Just the object’s name (e.g., “Digital Vernier Caliper”, “Soldering Iron”, “USB Flash Drive”)

ii. Description of Technical Objects

The description itself typically follows a structured pattern covering these elements:

1. **Definition/Introduction** – What the object is and its general category
2. **Physical appearance** – Shape, size, material, color, parts visible from outside
3. **Components/Parts** – Major parts and their names (labeled if possible)
4. **Working principle/Function** – How it works or what it is used for, step-by-step if relevant
5. **Uses/Applications** – Where and why it is used
6. **Conclusion** – A closing statement on its importance or advantage

Structure Template

Section	Content
Heading	Name of the object
Introduction	One-line definition/category
Body	Appearance → Parts → Working → Uses
Conclusion	Significance/advantage

Example: Description of a Stapler

Stapler

A stapler is a small mechanical device used to bind sheets of paper together using metal staples. It typically has a flat rectangular metal or plastic body, hinged in the middle to allow opening and closing. The main parts include the base plate, the staple magazine (which holds the staple pins), the striking plate, and the spring-loaded handle. To use it, staple pins are loaded into the magazine; when the handle is pressed down, the topmost staple is pushed through the paper and folded by the base plate to secure the sheets together. Staplers are widely used in offices, schools, and homes for organizing documents. Despite its simple design, it remains an essential tool for quick and efficient paper binding.

Tips for Writing Technical Object Descriptions

- Use **present tense** and **third person** ("It consists of...", not "I have...")
 - Use precise technical vocabulary (avoid vague words like "thing," "part," "stuff")
 - Follow a logical order: outer appearance → inner parts → function → use
 - Keep tone factual, not descriptive/emotional (this is different from a "descriptive paragraph" in Unit II)
 - Where possible, mention material, size, or specification for precision
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4.2 PICTURE DESCRIPTION

Picture description involves observing an image carefully and describing it in grammatically correct, well-organized English — testing observation skills and vocabulary.

i. Situational Picture

A situational picture shows people/objects engaged in a specific activity or event (e.g., a market scene, a classroom, an accident site, a family gathering). The goal is to describe **what is happening, who is involved, and the setting**.

Points to cover: 1. **Overall setting** – where the scene is taking place (location, time of day, weather if visible) 2. **Main subjects** – who/what is prominent in the picture 3. **Actions** – what each person/object is doing 4. **Background details** – secondary elements that add context 5. **Mood/atmosphere** – the overall feeling conveyed (busy, calm, chaotic, festive)

Example approach: > The picture shows a busy morning at a vegetable market. In the foreground, a vendor is arranging fresh tomatoes and onions on a wooden cart, while a customer bargains with him over the price. Several other shoppers are seen walking between stalls carrying bags. In the background, colorful umbrellas shade the stalls from the sun. The overall atmosphere appears lively and bustling, typical of a local morning market.

ii. Describe in Your Own Words

This emphasizes that picture description should not be a rigid checklist but a **natural, connected piece of writing** using your own observations and vocabulary — not copied phrases.

Points to keep in mind: - Use varied sentence structures (avoid repeating "There is/There are" for every sentence) - Use appropriate prepositions of place (in the foreground, in the background, to the left/right of, near, beside) - Use descriptive adjectives and correct tense (usually present continuous for ongoing actions: "is walking," "are talking") - Organize logically: general overview → specific details → concluding impression - Avoid guessing beyond what is visible (don't invent facts not shown in the picture)

Useful Vocabulary for Picture Description

Category	Useful Words/Phrases
Location	in the foreground, in the background, at the center, to the left/right
People	a group of, a crowd of, a young man/woman, an elderly person
Actions	is/are standing, walking, talking, holding, examining
Atmosphere	lively, calm, chaotic, cheerful, quiet, crowded
Time/Weather	early morning, bright sunny day, overcast sky, dusk

4.3 DIARY ENTRY

A diary entry is a personal, reflective record of the day's events, thoughts, or experiences, written in an informal, first-person style. It develops the ability to reflect on and articulate personal experiences in written English.

Structure of a Diary Entry

i. Date

- Written at the top, usually with day and sometimes time
- Format: *Monday, 14th August 2026* or *14th August 2026, 8:00 PM*

ii. Content

The main body, covering: 1. **Salutation (optional but common)** - "Dear Diary," 2. **Opening** - brief mention of what the entry is about 3. **Body** - detailed account of the event/experience/feelings, in chronological or thematic order 4. **Reflection** - personal thoughts, feelings, or lessons learned 5. **Closing thought** - a concluding remark, sometimes forward-looking ("I hope tomorrow brings...")

iii. Name of the Writer

- Diary entries are usually signed off informally (e.g., "Yours," "Goodnight," followed by the writer's name or simply left unsigned since it's personal)

Example Diary Entry

Monday, 14th August 2026

Dear Diary,

Today was an eventful day. I had my practical exam in the Communication Skills lab, and I was quite nervous before it began. However, once I started, I realized all the practice with picture description and dialogue writing had really paid off. My professor seemed pleased with my presentation on renewable energy. In the evening, I met my friends at the campus canteen, and we discussed our upcoming project submissions. I feel a mix of relief and excitement tonight — relief that the exam is over, and excitement for what's ahead this semester.

Goodnight, Riya

Tips for Writing a Diary Entry

- Use **first person** (“I felt...”, “I went...”)
- Keep the tone personal, honest, and reflective
- Use **past tense** for narrating events, but present/future tense for reflections or hopes
- Keep language simple and natural — it’s meant to sound like private, honest writing
- Stick to word limits if specified (your syllabus specifies 50 words for the practical activity)

4.4 TRANSLATION OF PARAGRAPH (English to Marathi/Hindi - Vice Versa)

Translation is the process of converting text from one language into another while preserving its **meaning, tone, and context** — not just converting word-for-word.

Important note from your syllabus: “*Question not to be asked on Translation in Theory Examination.*” This means translation is assessed only through practical/lab work (LLO 13.1), not in the written theory paper — but it is still an important applied skill.

Key Principles of Good Translation

1. **Meaning over word-for-word conversion** - Translate the *sense* of a sentence, not each word literally (literal translation often produces awkward or incorrect results)
2. **Maintain tone and register** - Formal English should translate into formal Marathi/Hindi, and informal into informal
3. **Handle idioms carefully** - Idiomatic expressions rarely translate literally; find the closest equivalent expression in the target language
4. **Grammar adjustment** - Sentence structure (word order, verb placement) differs between English (Subject-Verb-Object) and Hindi/Marathi (Subject-Object-Verb), so restructure accordingly
5. **Cultural context** - Some references may need slight adaptation to make sense in the target language/culture
6. **Proofread** - Re-read the translated version to ensure it reads naturally in the target language, not like a mechanical conversion

Example (Illustrative — English to Hindi)

English: “Technology has transformed the way we communicate with each other.” **Hindi (sense-based, not literal):** “प्रौद्योगिकी ने हमारे एक-दूसरे से संवाद करने के तरीके को बदल दिया है।”

(Note: Word order changes — Hindi places the verb at the end, unlike English.)

Common Errors to Avoid in Translation

- Translating idioms literally (e.g., translating “raining cats and dogs” word-for-word would confuse a Hindi/Marathi reader — use the equivalent expression instead)
- Ignoring grammatical gender rules in Hindi/Marathi (verbs and adjectives often change based on gender of the noun)
- Losing the original tone (formal passage translated too casually or vice versa)
- Omitting or adding information not present in the original

Practice Approach for Your Lab Activity

1. Read the full English paragraph first to understand overall meaning
 2. Identify key terms/technical words that may need special attention
 3. Translate sentence by sentence, adjusting word order for natural Hindi/Marathi flow
 4. Read the translated paragraph aloud to check it sounds natural
 5. Compare with the original to ensure no meaning was lost or altered
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Quick Revision Summary

Topic	Core Idea	Skill Developed
Technical Objects	Structured, objective description of tools/devices	Technical documentation skill
Picture Description	Describing situational images with organized observation	Observation & descriptive vocabulary
Diary Entry	Personal, reflective first-person writing	Self-expression & reflective writing
Translation	Sense-based conversion between English and Marathi/Hindi	Bilingual comprehension & adaptation

Aligned to CO4: “Use contextual words in English appropriately” and TLOs 4.1–4.4 as per MSBTE syllabus.